

Diners Around the World

Many American diners had closed by the 1970s, victims of the onslaught of fast-food chains. But nostalgia for the simpler postwar lifestyle and a love of '50s kitsch and Art Deco has sparked a new wave of retro-styled diners, in the US, Europe, and beyond.

SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA

101 Cafe inexpensive

631 South Coast Highway, Oceanside;
www.101Cafe.net

Built in 1928, the 101 Cafe has gone from diner to drive-in and back again. Painted with bright murals and filled with Highway 101 memorabilia, it serves classic diner meals and sandwiches, from French toast or buttermilk pancakes with bacon to meatloaf or double cheeseburgers with fries. The peanut butter malt is to die for.

Mel's Diner moderate

8585 Sunset Blvd., West Hollywood;
www.melsdrive-in.com

The original Mel's opened in 1947, and starred in the film *American Graffiti*, forming the backdrop for teenagers "cruising the strip" in California in 1962. Unfortunately, it was demolished shortly after shooting, but this second-generation diner – opened by the original owner's son – has recreated all the best parts, and has an outdoor patio where you can enjoy burgers and diner dinners under the neon lights.

The Nickel Diner moderate

524 South Main St., Los Angeles;
www.nickeldiner.com

Located in an old vaudeville theater in the newly-gentrified area around Skid Row, the Nickel Diner plays with the classic diner repertoire to create some truly exceptional dishes: try the Big Time Cheddar, maple bacon doughnuts, and the red velvet cake.

Ruby's Diner moderate

1128 W Lincoln Ave., Anaheim; www.rubys.com

Nab one of the carhop spaces here and you'll get your chili fries served on roller skates. Vintage decor and a great menu make it a blast from the past. Also at Laguna Beach, Huntington Beach, and other locations around the US.

REST OF THE US

From homey neighborhood hangouts to slick retro-style restaurants, everyone in America has a favorite diner. Those listed below stand out for their history – some are original O'Mahony prewar models – and their decor, atmosphere, and authenticity, as well as their delicious diner fare.

66 Diner inexpensive

1405 Central Ave. NE, Albuquerque, New Mexico;
www.66diner.com

Located right on historic Route 66, this fabulous diner has turquoise booths and golden oldies playing on the jukebox, and serves deluxe plates, blue-plate specials, and thick, creamy milk shakes from behind its shiny chrome and tiled counter.

Mickey's Dining Car inexpensive

36 West 7th St, St. Paul, Minnesota;
www.mickeysdiningcar.com

Fresh farm eggs, hand-shredded hash browns, spindle-blended milk shakes, and tasty family recipes have been served in this authentic O'Mahony diner since 1939. It's now considered so precious that it's listed on the National Register of Historic Places.

Summit Diner inexpensive

1 Union Place, Summit, New Jersey;
(908) 277 3256

Appropriately located opposite the train station, this 1938 Art Deco chrome beauty is another of the few remaining O'Mahony diners in the US. Enjoy Taylor ham (pork roll) and eggs with hash browns at the marble counter or in a red-leather booth.

Ed Debevic's moderate

640 N Wells St., Chicago, Illinois; www.eddebevics.com

Rude waitresses in beehive hairdos and horn-rimmed glasses who dance on the counter to '50s hits are all part of the experience at this fun, retro diner. Great shakes and burgers.

Rosie's Diner moderate

4500 14 Mile Rd. NE, Rockford, Michigan;
www.rosiesdiner.com

A long menu of home-cooked favorites, from their signature slow-roasted beef and noodles to sloppy-joe sandwiches and blue-plate specials, are served in this authentic 1946 diner.

